

# Bird facts

Evolving from two-legged dinosaurs, the first birds took flight about 140 million years ago. Today, birds are found on every continent and in a diverse range of habitats, from grasslands to deserts. Many birds migrate incredibly long distances to breed or find food.

## WHAT IS A BIRD?



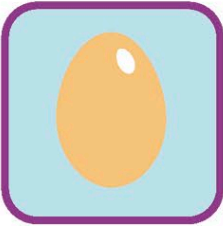
### Vertebrates

Birds have thin and lightweight, yet strong, internal skeletons made of bone.



### Warm-blooded

From humid rainforests to chilly mountaintops, birds generate and maintain a stable body temperature.



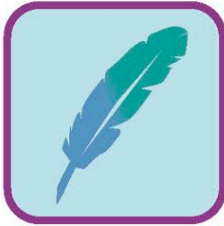
### Lay eggs

Birds breed by laying hard eggs, which chicks crack open when ready to hatch.



### Most fly

Using their wings, most birds can take to the skies, however some birds are flightless.

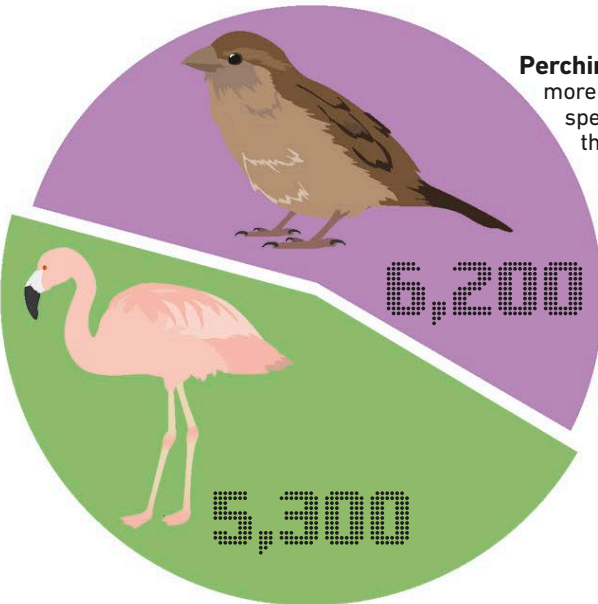


### Feathered

Feathers are important for retaining body heat and helping birds fly.

## BIRD TYPES

ESTIMATED NUMBER OF BIRD SPECIES: 11,500



**Perching birds** account for more than half of all bird species. Their feet have three unwebbed toes in the front and one strong, flexible toe on the back, allowing them to perch on tree branches. Found globally, they include sparrows, lyrebirds, and birds of paradise.

**Non-perching birds** account for all other species. They include a wide range of birds located across the world including parrots, owls, flamingos, and birds of prey, as well as flightless birds, such as ostriches, emus, and penguins.

COLOMBIA HAS OVER 1,850 BIRD SPECIES—MORE THAN ANY OTHER COUNTRY IN THE WORLD.



## HIBERNATING BIRD

The **common poorwill**, seen here on a roof, is the only bird species known to hibernate. Its diet of insects rapidly declines during winter, so it goes into a state of hibernation for weeks or even months. This bird is found in the grassy areas of North America.

## LONGEST MIGRATION

**ARCTIC TERNS** FLY AN AMAZING 59,650 MILES (96,000 KM) FROM THEIR BREEDING GROUND IN THE **NORTH ATLANTIC** TO **ANTARCTICA** AND BACK AGAIN.



## BIGGEST GATHERING

Flocks of more than 1.5 billion red-billed quelea have been witnessed flying over the African savanna. In such great numbers, this small bird is a constant threat to crop farmers. In fact, it is such a pest, it is often called the "feathered locust."